

Samantha Vargas-Markham

Brooklyn, NY · U.S. Permanent Resident — no sponsorship required · sa4292@columbia.edu ·
linkedin.com/in/samantha-vargas-markham

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Former elected legislator and senior executive with a decade of high-stakes policy delivery across government, civil society and technology — now a hands-on builder of AI systems. Founder of Handa, a responsible-AI legal-aid platform on the Claude API, and author of ongoing research on AI surveillance and migrant rights. Brings rare fluency across legislative process, multilateral diplomacy and applied AI development to governance roles at the frontier of the field. English, French, Tagalog.

EXPERIENCE

Founder & Chief Executive — Handa

Responsible-AI legal-aid platform

2024 – present

- **Own the full safety surface** of an agentic legal-aid product on the Claude API: pre-response evaluation for accuracy, bias and hallucination; confidence-threshold gating; explicit refusal behaviour; human escalation for high-stakes cases affecting a vulnerable, non-English-first user population.
- **Red-team the deployment** against hallucinated legal guidance, biased outputs and unsafe autonomous actions, translating findings into concrete guardrails and intervention checkpoints.
- **Architected the product end to end** — React Native front end, Claude API reasoning layer, Node.js services, Supabase backend — including the evaluation harness used to decide whether an answer is safe to show a worker with no lawyer and no leverage.
- **Built the partner ecosystem** across government, multilateral, NGO, technology and legal organisations (OWWA, ILO, Lawyers Without Borders, Migrant Forum in Asia) for an addressable population of 2M+ overseas Filipino workers — every function, solo.

Founder & Operator — the Margins Studio

AI-automated commerce

2025 – present

- **Built an autonomous storefront agent** running a print-on-demand business end to end: Claude Vision artwork analysis → product selection → SEO listing generation → automated publishing.
- **Built gate.js**, a pre-publish moderation layer screening every AI-generated listing against quality, brand and IP criteria — a working automated-enforcement checkpoint with a hand-defined rule set.
- **Built feedback.js**, a weekly performance digest pushed to Telegram, so the agent's output is measured rather than assumed.
- Operate a multi-platform commerce business across Etsy, Depop, eBay and Poshmark — sourcing, pricing, automation and fulfilment, single operator.

Assistant Secretary — Presidential Legislative Liaison Office

Office of the President, Republic of the Philippines

2022 – 2024

- **Delivered a 100% priority bill passage rate** across a contested legislative term, coordinating multi-agency positions and holding alignment across competing branches of government.
- **Led passage of national e-commerce regulation** and built the content-governance rails inside it: harmful-content definitions, review and enforcement processes, human-in-the-loop escalation and platform-accountability provisions.
- **Served as executive lead on Enhanced Defense Cooperation Agreement implementation**, negotiating interagency consensus on technology and security provisions.
- **Ran the operating interface** between the President's office and both chambers: priority sequencing, cross-agency decision forcing, briefing pipeline, executive briefing and follow-up.
- Coordinated interagency responses to West Philippine Sea developments, ASEAN summits and bilateral agreements; designed communications strategy for sensitive national security and energy legislation.

Member of Congress — Philippine House of Representatives

12-municipality district, c. 300,000 constituents

2019 – 2022

- **Elected at 26.** Secured a **\$20M regional medical facility** — the first modern healthcare anchor for the district — and **\$14M+ in social-services funding**.
- Delivered **12% year-over-year district budget growth** through transparent, data-driven resource allocation across a full three-year term.
- Built multi-channel constituent communications infrastructure: **+40% stakeholder engagement, +23% voter engagement**.
- Represented the Philippines in ASEAN fora including the Inter-Parliamentary Assembly, negotiating shared regulatory standards on West Philippine Sea maritime rules.

Assistant Project Manager — Migrant Forum in Asia

Rights-based research and policy advocacy

2015 – 2016

- Co-authored and published the **Passport Confiscation Matrix**, a comparative policy tool mapping documentation-abuse practices and remedies across the Asia–Gulf corridor.
- Drove the Lawyers Beyond Borders activation in Malaysia, building multi-country legal-response capability; built coalitions across NGOs, governments and multilateral bodies.

RESEARCH & APPLIED AI

- **WPS Maritime Tracker — incident-to-award evidentiary system.** 16 structured records of West Philippine Sea incidents, each mapped to UNCLOS articles, COLREGs rules and 2016 Arbitral Award holdings, with Berkeley Protocol-informed provenance, an append-only SHA-256 custody chain anchored via OpenTimestamps, and a publication whitelist releasing only adjudicated records. A Claude pipeline structures open-source reporting; every record it produces requires human adjudication before publication.
- **“The Canary in the Dragnet” (2026).** Policy research arguing migrants are the first population on whom AI surveillance infrastructure is normalised, making migrant-rights failure a leading indicator of general AI governance failure. Submitted to the CHT Emerging Voices Fellowship; builds on the Passport Confiscation Matrix and the 2018 Paris thesis.
- **Columbia SIPA capstone for UN DESA (2025).** Monitoring framework for Fourth International Conference on Financing for Development commitments — baseline against the Addis Ababa Action Agenda, legacy measurement gaps, SMART and proxy indicators mapped to institutional stakeholders and data sources.
- **SolBound — incentive design prototype.** Reward mechanics and abuse-resistance model for a sober-to-earn recovery application: rewarding a behaviour only the user can verify, without creating an exploit that falls hardest on the intended beneficiaries.

EDUCATION

Columbia University, SIPA — Executive M.P.A., Management & Innovation. Capstone delivered to UN DESA — a monitoring framework for the Fourth International Conference on Financing for Development. Also: Executive Course in Digital Strategy, Columbia Business School.

Saïd Business School, University of Oxford — Executive Leadership Programme.

American Graduate School in Paris & Université Paris-Saclay — Double Master's, International Relations & Conflict Negotiation, Cum Laude; Certificate in NGO Management. Thesis: *Why Do States Bypass International Human Rights Commitments: A Case Study of the GCC and ILO Conventions*.

Sciences Po Rennes — Certificate, Political Science and French.

Ateneo de Manila University — B.A., European Studies; minor in French.

SKILLS

Governance: AI governance · responsible-AI frameworks · policy drafting & implementation · regulatory strategy · harm taxonomies · content policy & platform integrity · enforcement strategy · stakeholder alignment · executive briefing.

Applied AI: LLM APIs (Anthropic Claude) · Model Context Protocol · prompt design & evaluation · agentic pipelines · Claude Vision · red-teaming & failure-mode analysis · guardrail and escalation design · React Native · Node.js · Supabase.

Operations: priority sequencing · cross-functional decision forcing · budget & resource allocation · briefing infrastructure · automation & workflow design · P&L ownership · reactive and crisis messaging.

Languages: English, French, Tagalog.